

B-AD 4013 has provided me with numerous valuable life lessons. Beyond books, I also found the other case studies to be engaging and enjoyable. I genuinely found pleasure in discussing these cases with friends during social gatherings and that's when I learned that I enjoyed it. Within the book, there are many strategic issues to explore, and I consider some of the most significant ones to be:

1. **Clear vision:** In my personal opinion, B-AD is a course designed to learn how to run a company. I believe the top priority of a company to step in the market should be vision. A vision must be achievable but with integrity and honesty. It is important because the framework will be adhered to by employees, stakeholders, and all individuals associated with the organization. Vision is a fundamental backbone of a company.

Consider, for instance, the case of the Saatchi and Saatchi brothers, who relentlessly pursued the ambition of securing the top position in their field. However, their failure to recognize the potential within their specialized market led them to diversify into unrelated sectors like consulting and dental services, ultimately leading to the downfall of their advertising firm. Had they adhered to a focused vision, the company might have retained its dominance in the advertising industry.

The absence of a clear vision can lead to the dissolution of a company. Similarly, in personal life, I think an individual without a vision may never find satisfaction as they lack a specific destination to strive for or achieve.

2. **Learning from mistakes:** Learning from mistakes is crucial in both life and business. Recognizing where and what mistakes we did helps us avoid repeating them and fosters improvement. Studying case studies, like those in "Why Smart Executives Fail," allows us to learn from the missteps of others. Snow Brand Milk serves as an example of

repeated disasters. These issues hold significance for firms because while the first mistake may be inevitable, subsequent mistakes of the same nature are definitely within the firm's control. For example, had Snow Brand Milk learned from their initial cleanliness oversight, they might have avoided subsequent mistakes related to cow diseases. Therefore, for any firm, learning from both its own mistakes and those of others is vital for growth and progress.

3. **Innovation and change:** Businesses must continuously innovate to adapt to changing market dynamics and maintain a competitive edge. Managing innovation involves fostering a culture of creativity, implementing new technologies and processes, and effectively managing change to ensure smooth transitions and organizational growth. Customers change and their preference changes all the time. As the saying goes, “The only constant in life is change”. And it is inevitable, therefore, as a company it is very important to learn how to adapt with it to stay on the top of the firm. I really admired the CEO of Walmart we studied where he mentioned, Walmart **will** stay ahead in the market because of their technique to adapt to change. In student life, adaptation mirrors the change of courses, friends, group work, and professors each semester. The syllabus varies with each professor, requiring students to smoothly adapt to diverse environments.

Do you think the issues identified in your book are generalizable to all firms like profit, public, non-profit, and governmental agencies? Why or why not?

The issues identified in the book are generalizable to all firms like profit, public, non-profit, and governmental agencies with few exceptions. While there may be specialized cases exclusive to particular market industries, many instances are broadly applicable across all agency types. The book provides numerous examples such as Johnson & Johnson, Stachi brothers, Rubbermaid,

Samsung, Sony, Wand Lab which are international cases across various industries and agency types, with cases selected to offer a broader, more generalized perspective. Firstly, the book divides the chapters with cases into the general topic such as, “great corporate mistakes”, “causes of failure”, “learning from mistakes”. These are great lessons that can be applicable not just for firms but also in personal life. Secondly, the chapter explains the idea of businesses such as “innovation and change” or “Mergers and acquisition”, to prove this then the example of firms are given. While the corporate industries and non-profit might be in different markets. Both of these are crucial lessons for any kind of firm.

However, there are specialized cases like "Wang Lab" that cater to niche markets. The story of Wang Labs primarily revolves around the dynamics of for-profit business ventures, focusing on entrepreneurial pursuits, technological innovation, and market competition. Non-profit and governmental agencies typically operate within different frameworks, where profitability and market dominance are not primary objectives. As such, the specific challenges and strategic decisions faced by Wang Labs may not directly translate to the context of non-profit or governmental organizations. Non-profit organizations, for instance, are driven by social or charitable missions rather than profit maximization. Their priorities often revolve around fundraising, community outreach, and program delivery, which involve different considerations and challenges compared to for-profit ventures like Wang Labs. Similarly, governmental agencies are subject to regulatory oversight, political mandates, and public accountability, which shape their decision-making processes and strategic priorities in distinct ways. While they may encounter challenges related to innovation and adaptation, the dynamics of competition and market positioning, as seen in the Wang Labs case, are less applicable to governmental organizations.

I believe while the issues identified in the book offer valuable insights for various types of organizations, such as profit, public, non-profit, and governmental agencies, there are limitations in their direct applicability across all contexts.

What surprised you in this book and why?

The title was very catchy, “Why smart executives fail”. It was nice the book wasn't like a typical normal textbook type but something that anyone could read for personal growth. I like how every chapter was unrelated to the previous one and there are different case studies in diverse industries. I also really like how the cases were from international countries and all different years and very different from one another. Additionally, I like the way we covered it in class, as we have finished almost all the syllabus and already covered two books. This book was resourceful as there were so many cases and all based on real life interesting ones.

Finally, the cases we discussed in class were both valuable and enjoyable. As I mentioned earlier, I often find myself discussing these cases with friends, sharing stories like how Accenture was founded with a friend who works there, or discussing the case of Supersonic with another friend, an OKC Thunder fan. Overall, I feel like I've gained a lot of knowledge and insights from the books and class discussions, which have contributed to my personal growth.